← All case studies

PUBLIC SECTOR · CITY OPERATIONS

What is Toronto calling 311 about, and which requests stay open?

1.35 million 311 requests from 2023 to 2025: what drives demand, which divisions leave requests unresolved, and a change in request types that breaks year-over-year comparisons.

Real data | Power BI | Power Query | DAX | SQL | Python

Requests in 2025

▲ 14.5% vs 2024

500,269

Resolved

of 2025 requests

80.5%

Still open

of 2025 requests

7.8%

Parks & forestry still open

▲ 45.1 pts vs other divisions

49.4%

Busiest month in 2025

53,707 requests, lifted by new snow request types

Feb 2025

Quietest month in 2025

32,793 requests

Jan 2025

Parks & forestry share of open requests

of all open requests, from 7.5% of requests

47.9%

The question

Where does the city leave requests unresolved, and what is behind the growth in 311 demand?

The data

Customer-initiated 311 requests for 2023, 2024 and 2025: 1,351,594 rows with creation time, status, location (postal area or intersection), ward, request type, division and section. There is no close date, so time to close cannot be measured. Source: Open Data Toronto, 311 Service Requests - Customer Initiated (Open Government Licence - Toronto).

THE DATA AT A GLANCE

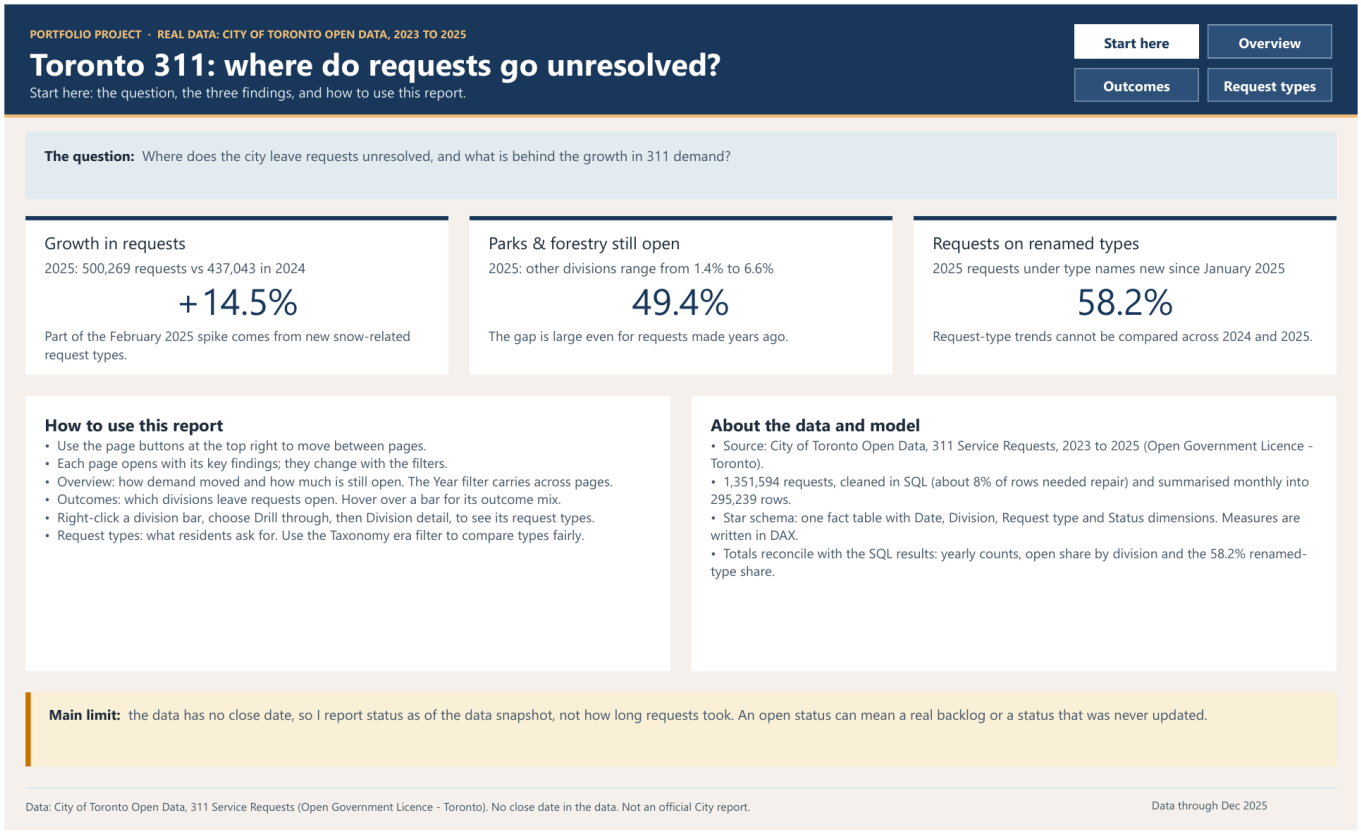
1,351,594
requests, 2023 to 2025

829
request types, each in one division

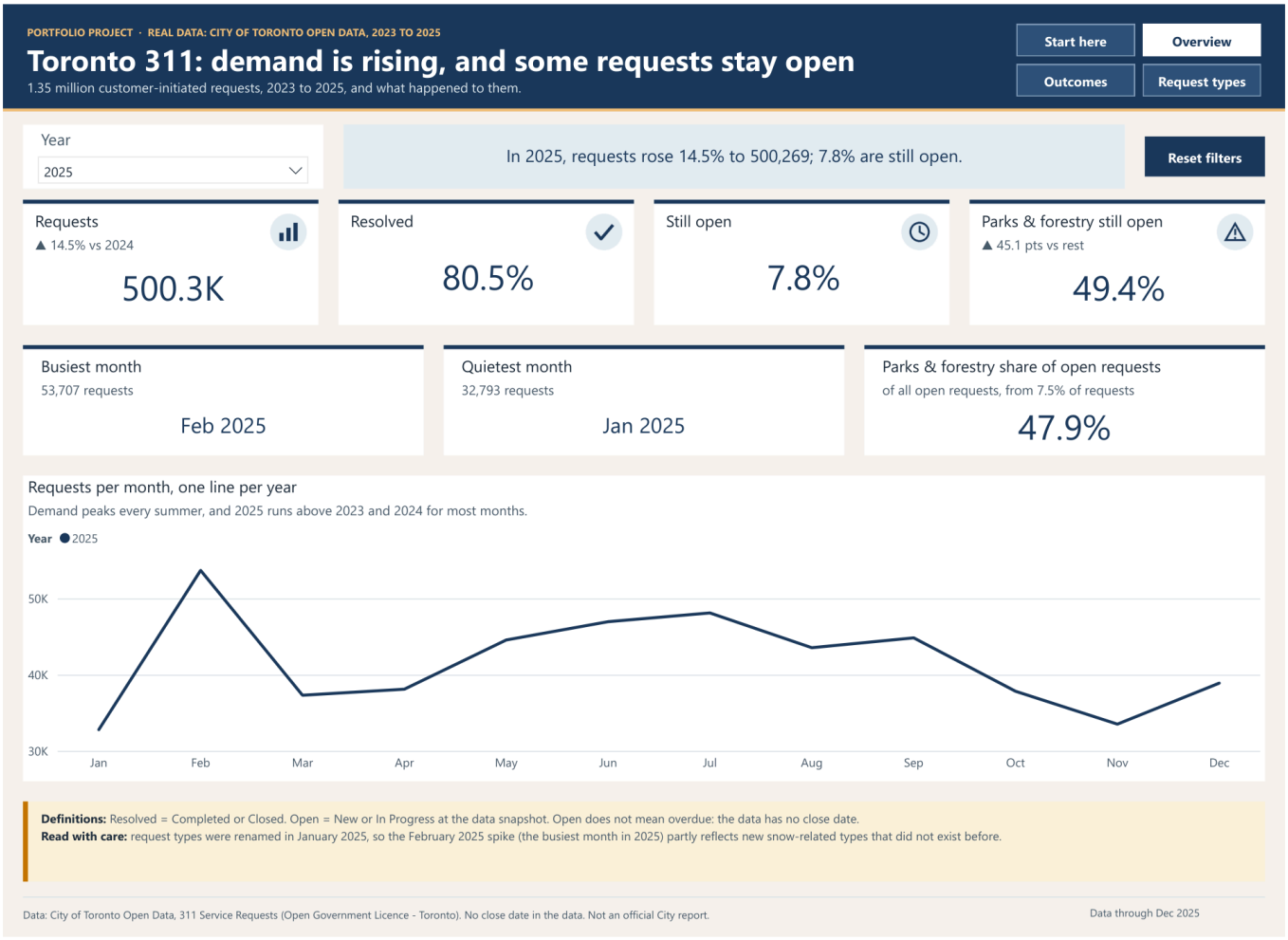
7
divisions

295,239
rows after monthly summary

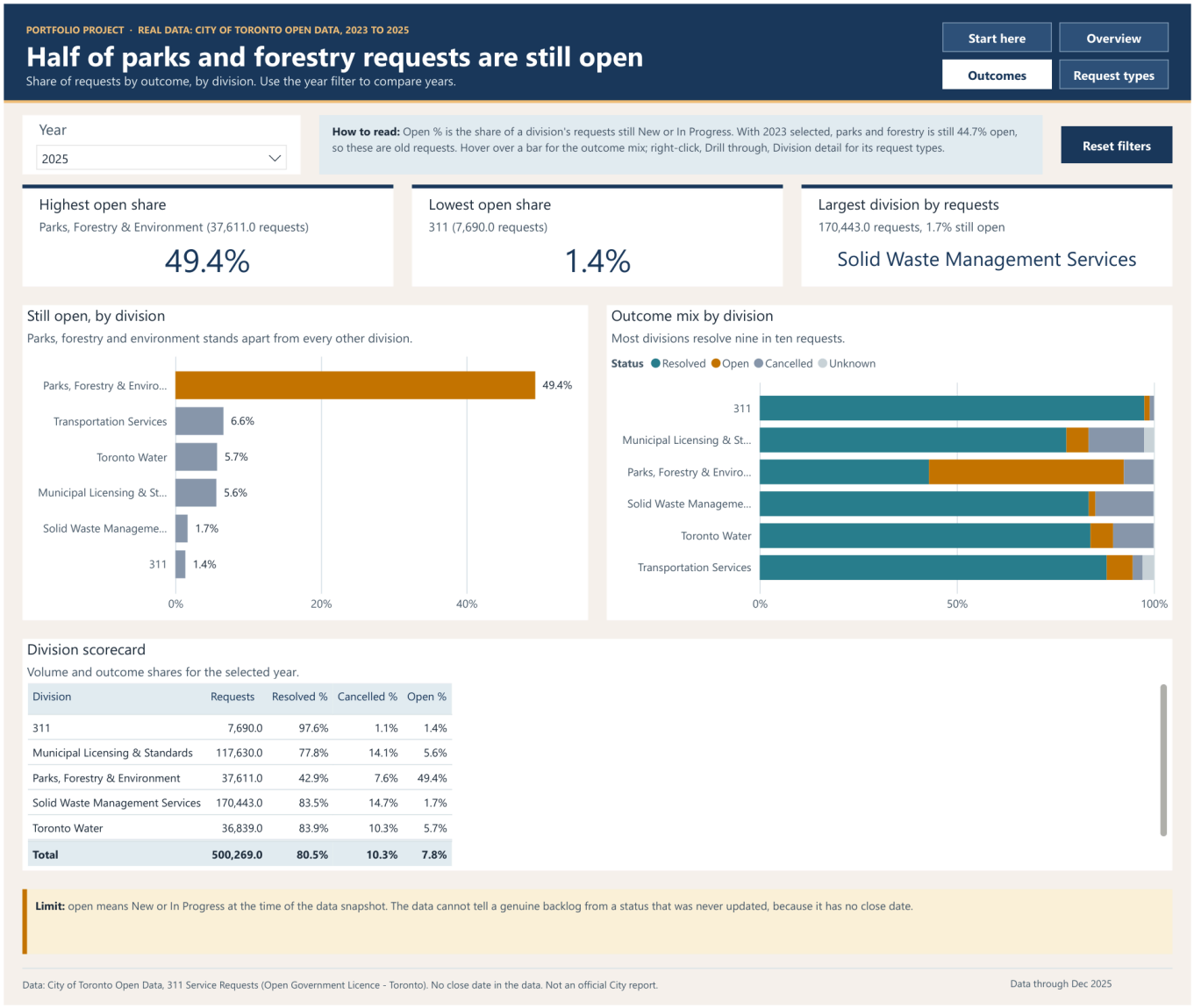
The Power BI report



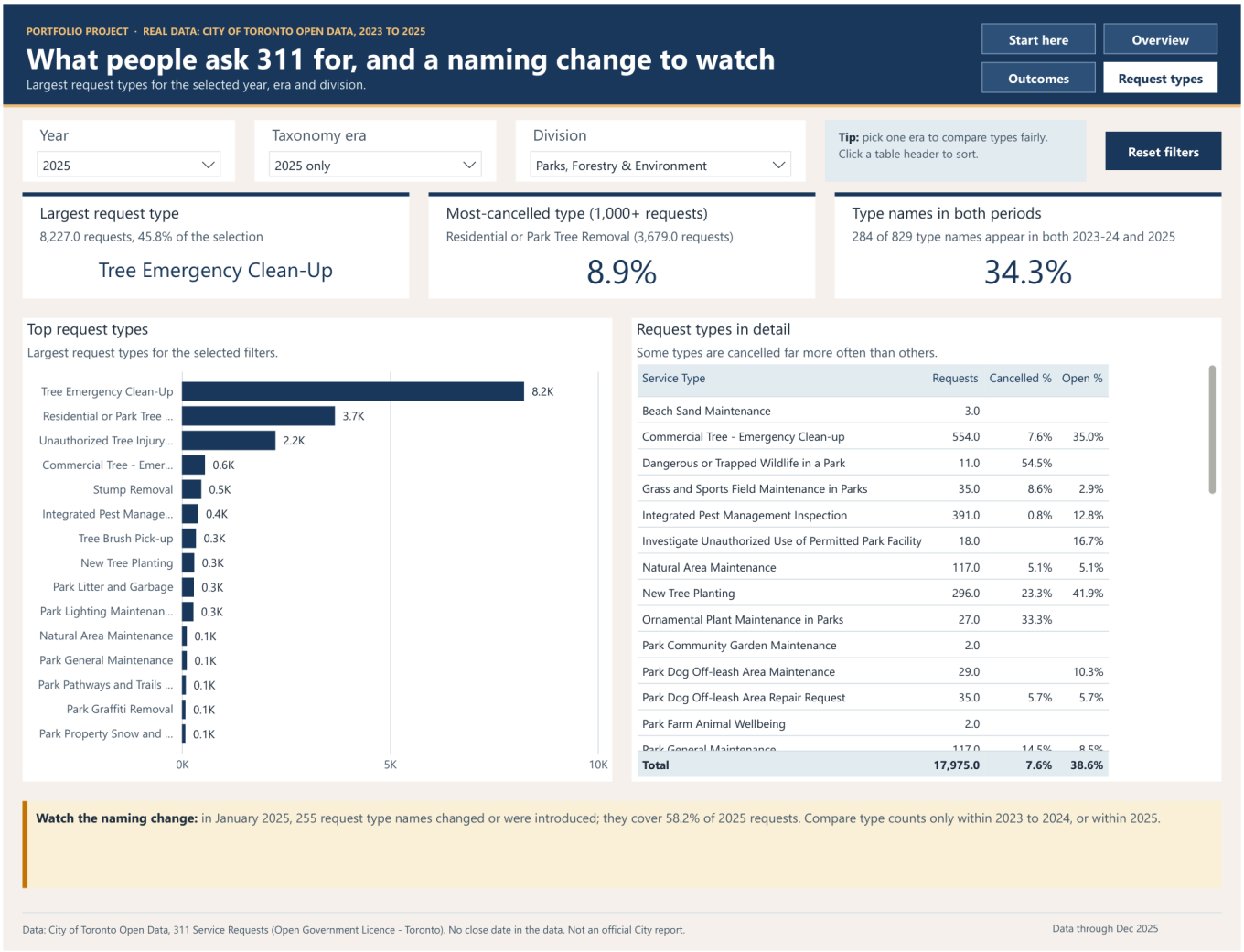
Start here: the question, three live findings and how to use the report (click to enlarge)



Overview: demand by month, key findings and year-over-year change (click to enlarge)



Outcomes: share of requests still open by division, with drill-through to request types (click to enlarge)



Request types: top types, taxonomy-era filter and the naming-change warning (click to enlarge)

Key findings

1. Requests grew from 414,282 in 2023 to 437,043 in 2024 and 500,269 in 2025, up 14.5% in 2025.

2. Parks, forestry and environment is the outlier: 49.4% of its 2025 requests are still open (18,597 of 37,611), and so are 44.7% of its 2023 requests (12,637 of 28,298). Every other division is between 1.4% and 6.6% open. General pruning is 66% open and tree removal 73%.

3. The request-type list changed in January 2025: 255 type names appear only in 2025 and cover 58.2% of that year's

4. Between 2023 and 2024, the fastest-growing named types were litter and

requests (for example, bin lid repairs were renamed). Growth by type cannot be compared across that boundary.

illegal dumping cleanup (+46.8%) and bin lid repair or replacement (+36.6%).

5 10.3% of 2025 requests were cancelled, but dead-wildlife pick-up was cancelled 38.8% of the time (6,026 of 15,513) and missed recycling pick-up 28.6%.

6 February 2025 had 53,707 requests, against 24,871 in February 2024. 19,876 of them were snow-related types that exist only from January 2025, so I cannot tell how much was more demand and how much better capture.

01

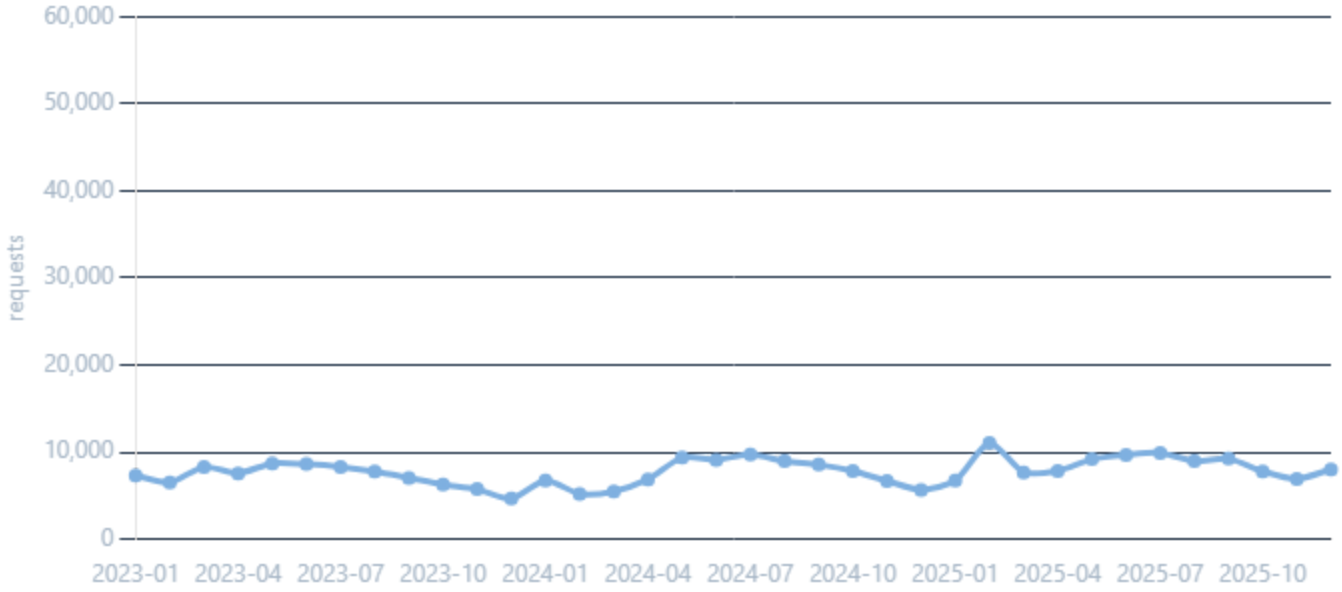
Demand rose 14.5% in 2025

Requests went from 414,282 in 2023 to 437,043 in 2024 and 500,269 in 2025. Part of the February 2025 spike comes from snow-related request types that only exist from January 2025, so the true rise in demand is smaller than the headline suggests.

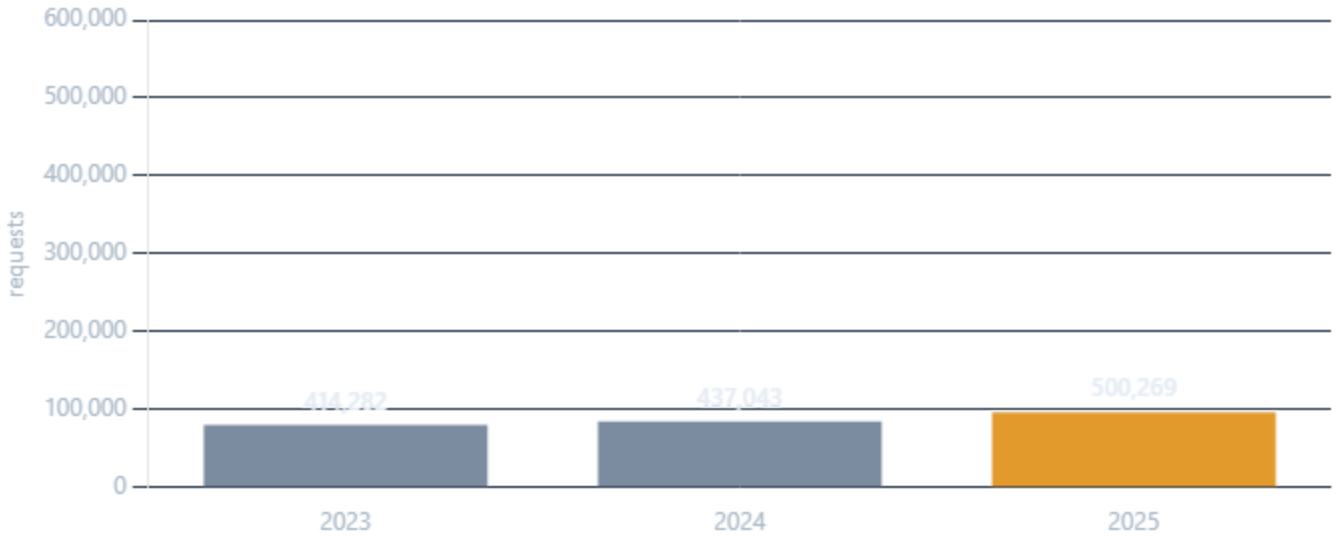
+14.5%

more requests in 2025 than in 2024

311 REQUESTS PER MONTH, 2023 TO 2025



REQUESTS BY YEAR



02

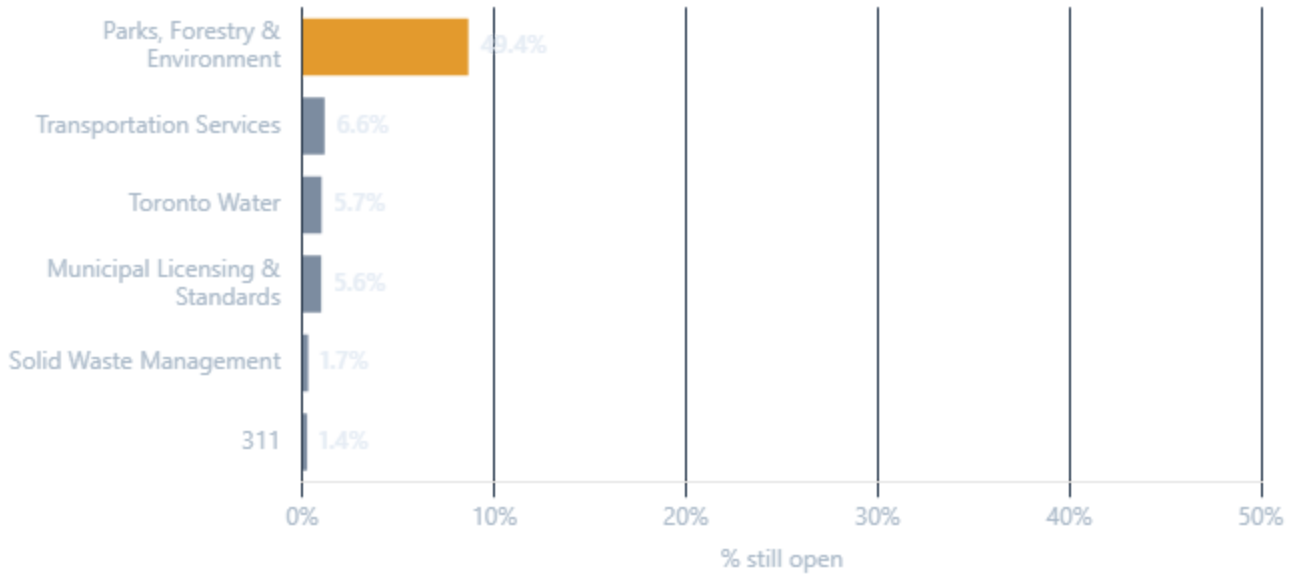
Half of parks and forestry requests are still open

49.4% of 2025 requests in parks, forestry and environment are open, and so are 44.7% of its 2023 requests, so these are old requests and not only recent ones. Every other division is between 1.4% and 6.6%. Within the division, general pruning is 66.2% open and tree removal 73.3%. The data cannot say whether this is a backlog or statuses nobody updated.

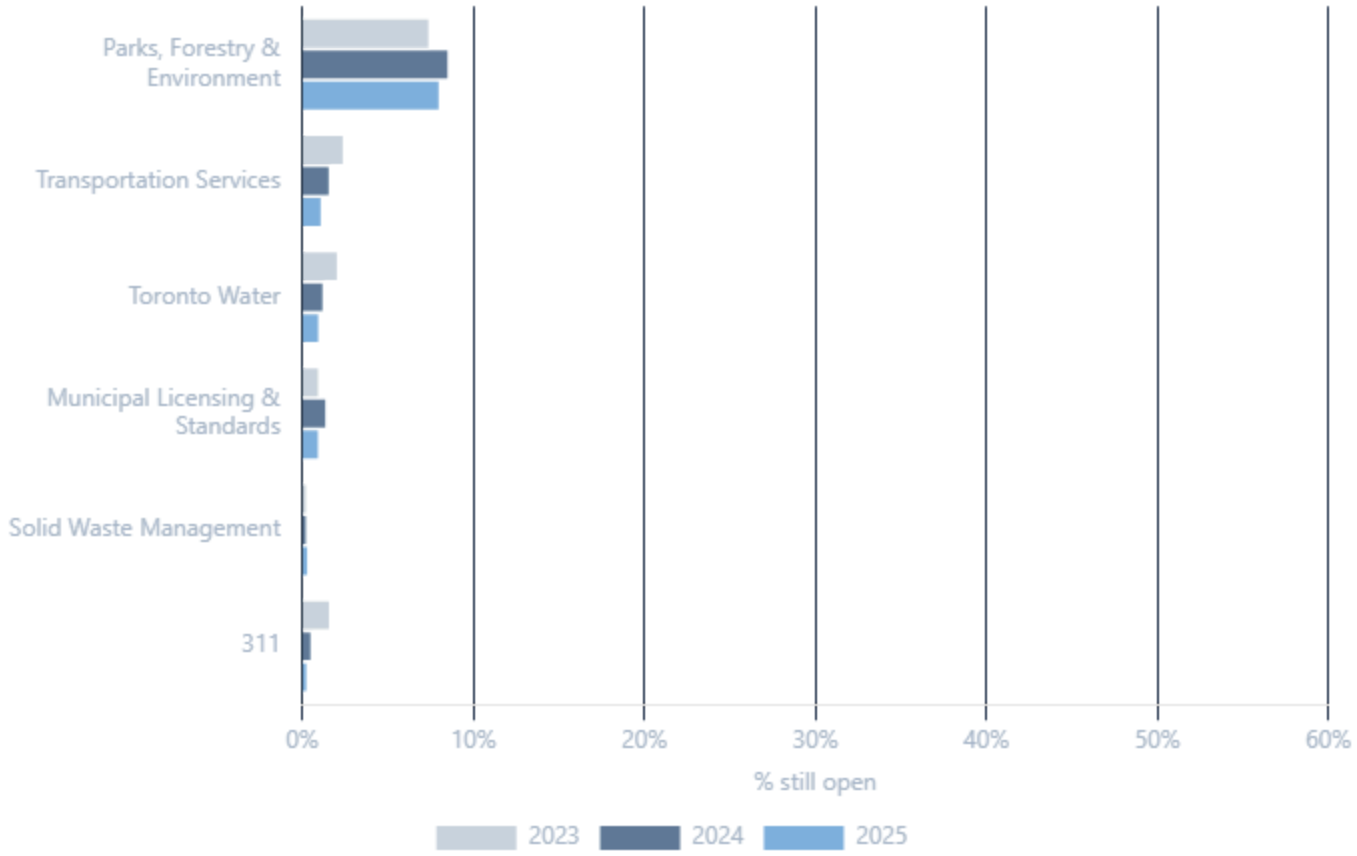
49.4%

of 2025 parks, forestry and environment requests are open

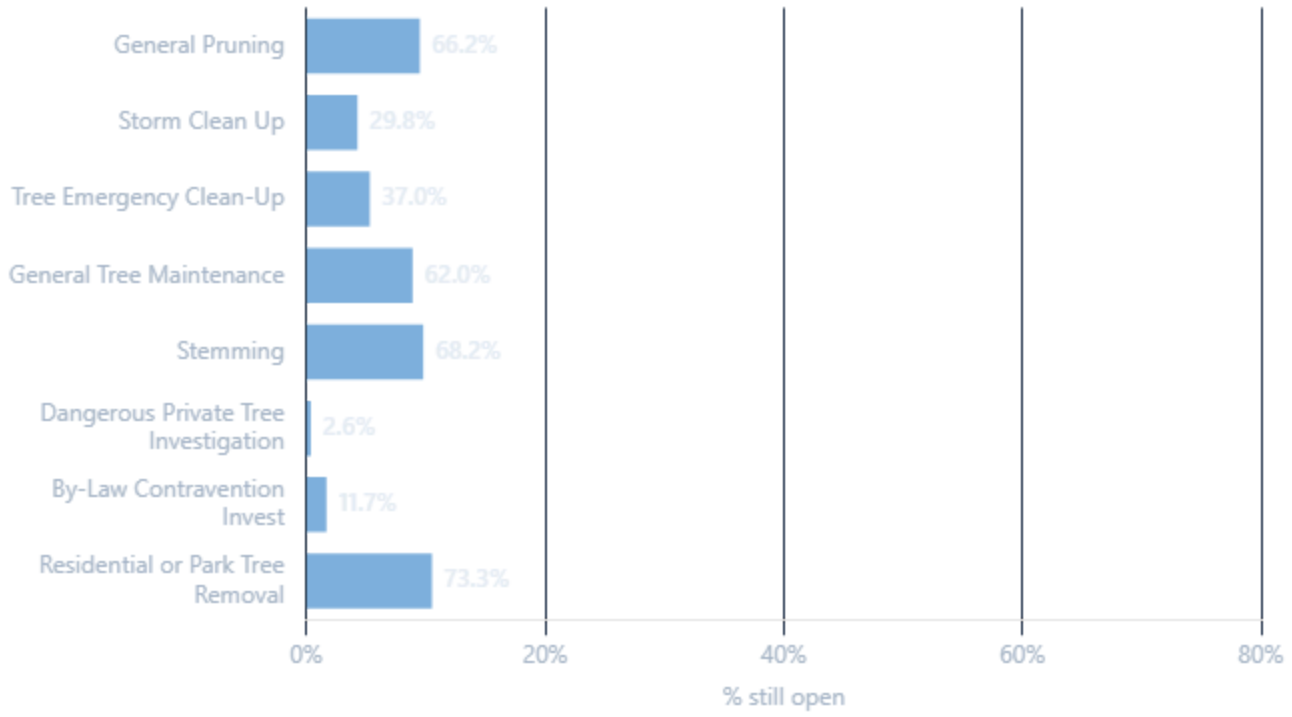
SHARE OF 2025 REQUESTS STILL OPEN, BY DIVISION



SHARE STILL OPEN, BY DIVISION AND YEAR



PARKS, FORESTRY AND ENVIRONMENT: SHARE STILL OPEN, BY REQUEST TYPE (2023 TO 2025)



03

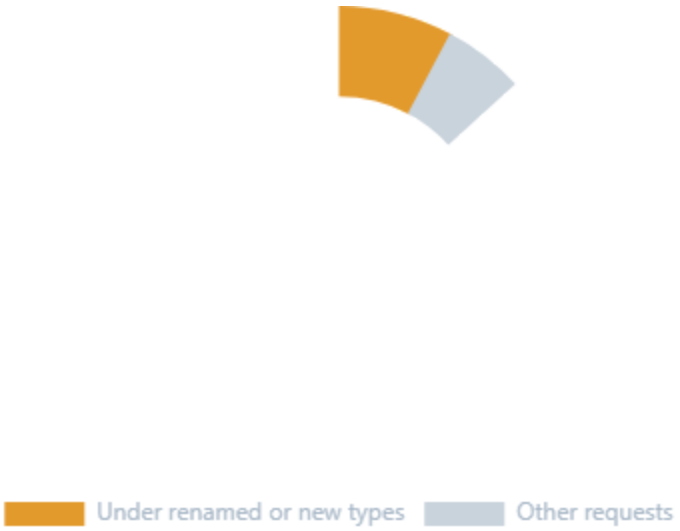
Request types were renamed in January 2025

255 type names appear only in 2025 and cover 58.2% of that year's requests. Type-level growth is only valid within 2023 to 2024 or within 2025, so the report adds a Taxonomy Era filter instead of comparing across the break.

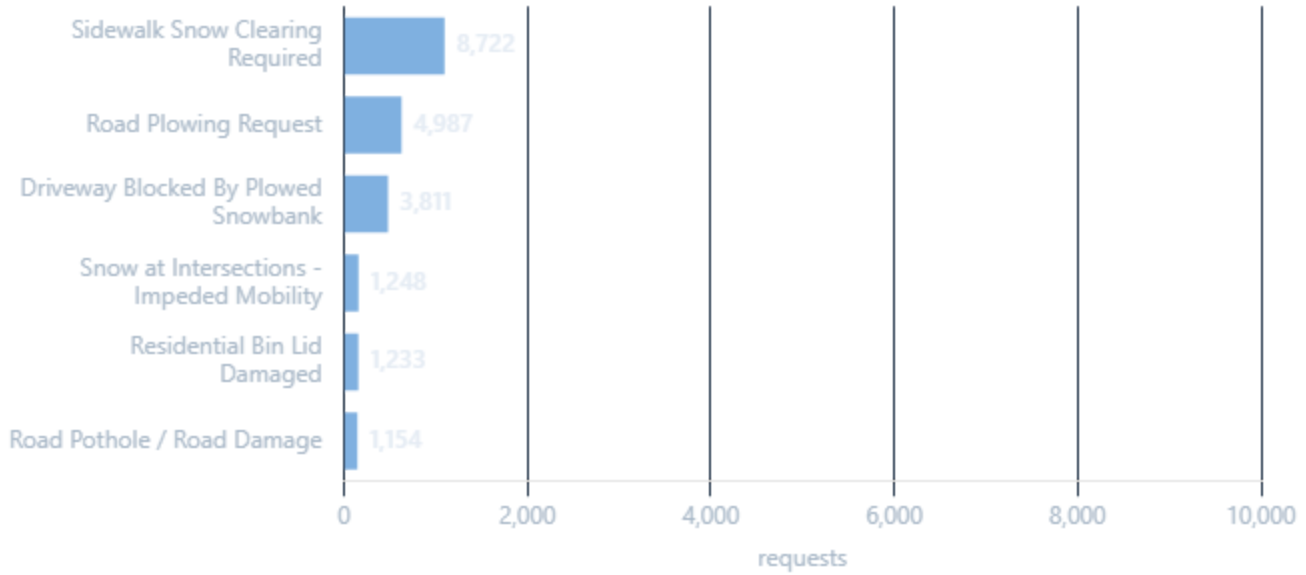
58.2%

of 2025 requests use type names introduced in January 2025

2025 REQUESTS BY TYPE-NAME STATUS



FEBRUARY 2025 REQUESTS FOR TYPE NAMES THAT DID NOT EXIST IN FEBRUARY 2024



04

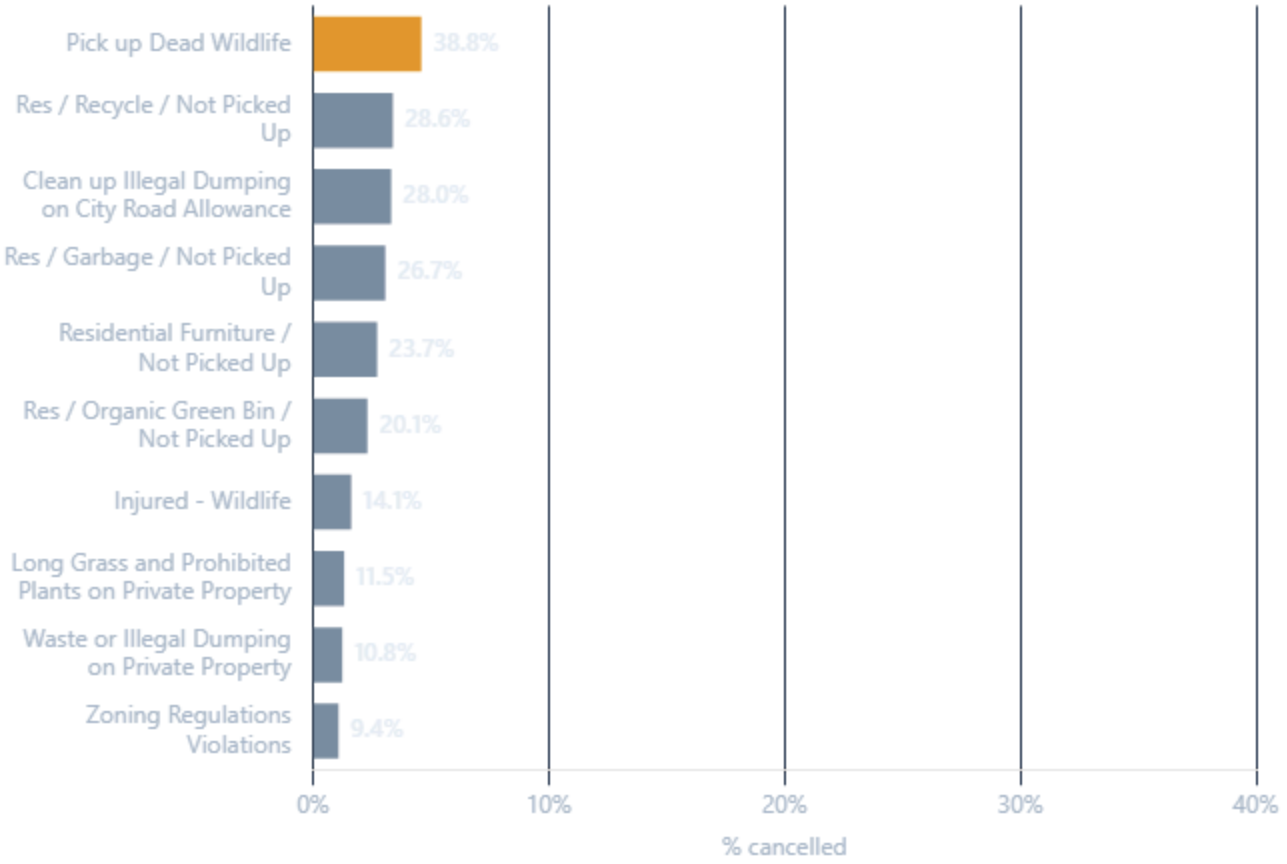
Some types are cancelled far more often than others

10.3% of 2025 requests were cancelled overall, but dead-wildlife pick-up was cancelled 38.8% of the time (6,026 of 15,513) and missed recycling pick-up 28.6%. Duplicate or repeat calls are one possible reason; I have not tested it.

38.8%

of dead-wildlife pick-up requests were cancelled in 2025

SHARE CANCELLED IN 2025, 10 HIGHEST AMONG TYPES WITH 5,000+ REQUESTS



What I would recommend

1

Check whether the old open forestry requests are a real backlog or statuses that were never updated, and publish expected waits for pruning and tree removal.

2

Add the closed date to the open dataset. It is the single most useful missing field.

3

Publish a mapping table whenever request types are renamed, so year-over-year comparisons stay possible.

4

Review the cancel-heavy types, such as dead-wildlife pick-up and missed recycling, to test whether duplicate or repeat calls are behind the cancellations. This is a hypothesis I have not tested.

What I did

- Download the three yearly files and repair about 8% of rows where an unquoted comma split the division name into two fields.
- Group the Parks and Forestry division with its 2025 successors, since it was renamed and split.
- Group status into Resolved, Cancelled, Open and Unknown, and reconcile row counts against the source files.
- Run ten SQL queries for volume, outcomes, divisions, types and seasonality, then build the Power BI report from a monthly summary table.

Model and measures

The report is built on a star schema: one fact table of monthly request counts, and four small dimension tables that hold the names, so filters are fast and every measure reads the same way.

Key measures

Open %

```
DIVIDE ( CALCULATE ( [Requests], requests[status_group] = "Open" ), [Requests] )
```

Requests YoY %

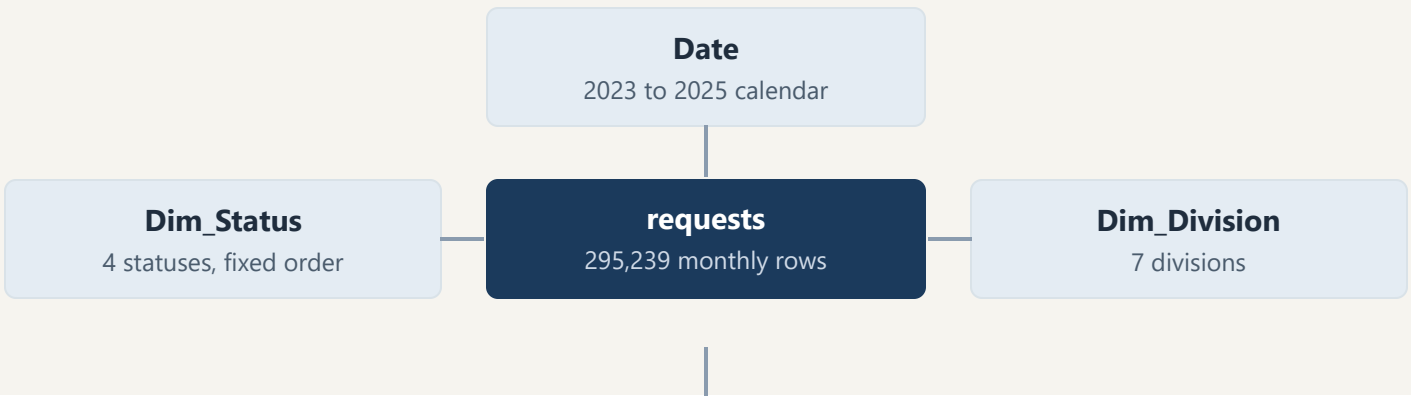
```
DIVIDE ( [Requests] - [Requests PY], [Requests PY] )
```

Taxonomy Era

```
IF ( early > 0 && late > 0, "In both periods", IF ( early > 0, "2023-24 only", "2025 only" ) )
```

Imported from a 33 MB monthly summary of the full request file, so the report stays fast. Results were reconciled against the SQL: totals, yearly counts, open share by division and the 58.2% renamed-type share all match.

STAR SCHEMA



Dim_ServiceType
829 types, era flag

Limits of this analysis

- No close date: I report request status as of the data snapshot, not how long anything took.
- An open status could mean a genuine backlog or a status never updated. The data cannot separate the two.
- Request type names changed in January 2025, so type-level comparisons are valid only within 2023 to 2024 or within 2025.
- Ward counts are not adjusted for population, and requests reflect who reports as well as where problems occur.
- 1.5% of requests have an Unknown status and are excluded from the resolved share.

Reproduce it

Code, SQL and the method write-up: 03-government-311/ on GitHub.

Data sources and limits are listed on each case study.